

Safety and Risk Management

TCS3111

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Company Policy Statement and Policies

Why do we need an occupational health and safety (OHS) policy statement?

- Written occupational health and safety policy helps promote an effective OHS program.
- Reflect the special needs of your workplace and should be regularly reviewed and updated.
- Assist you in writing and applying a policy for your workplace.
- Communicates a commitment to health and safety. It should be signed by a senior manager or president to further demonstrate the commitment to health and safety



What is a policy?

- The Gage dictionary defines “policy” as “a **plan of action; a course or method of action that has been deliberately chosen and that guides or influences future decisions.**”
- By stating principles and rules, an occupational health and safety policy guides actions.
- A policy statement indicates the degree of an employer's commitment to health and safety.
- The statement of the employers' obligation should be more than an outline of legal duties.



What makes a policy statement effective?

To be effective, a policy must:

- involve senior management and representatives in the preparation of the policy,
- be seen as consistent with the workplace's objectives of operating in an efficient and predictable manner,
- be relevant and appropriate to the nature, scale and OHS hazards and risk associated with that workplaces' needs (not adopted from another workplace), and
- be accepted as equal in importance to the workplace's other policy objectives



What types of issues should the OHS policy statement cover?

- senior management's commitment to the establishment of a healthy and safe workplace and to the integration of health and safety into all workplace activities,
- the commitment to comply with applicable OHS legal requirements and other requirements – or better, the intention to treat applicable health and safety legislation as a minimum standard rather than maximum,
- responsibility of appropriate personnel in maintaining a healthy and safe workplace and to protect the well-being of all persons in the workplace,
- accountability of all levels of management for carrying out health and safety responsibilities,



What types of issues should the OHS policy statement cover?

- importance of consultation and co-operation between management and employees for effective implementation of policy and any related programs,
- commitment to continual improvement by conducting regular reviews of the policy,
- commitment to monitor the policy's effectiveness by having a method for setting and reviewing OHS objectives and targets,
- that the policy will be documented, posted, and communicated internally as well as externally, as appropriate, and
- commitment to provide adequate funds and details of how money will be available.



Who should write the policy?

- The best policies are specific to a workplace and reflect the nature, scale and OHS hazards and risk for that workplace.
- An employer may delegate the preparation of a policy to a staff member.
- The policy should be written in consultation with the health and safety committee or representative, or with workers or their representatives.
- However the written occupational health and safety policy statement is a pledge to employees and therefore the employer is responsible for content.
- The safety policy should be dated and signed by the senior executive of workplace.



What should be considered when writing the policy?

These are some of the major items to consider.

- The policy should state the arrangements in place to support and implement it. Such items as safety meetings, safe working procedures, occupational hygiene, and education and training should be outlined.
- The policy should address the types of hazards associated with the workplace. Depending on the types of tasks performed and the hazards present, it may be necessary for the employer to become fairly specific and detailed in outlining hazards at the workplace.
- The policy should discuss active and on-going participation of employees in helping to achieve the objectives.
- Policy statements need to be amended from time to time. They must keep pace with the changes occurring at the workplace.



What should be considered when writing the policy?

The following are questions that need to be considered for preparation of a policy:

- What is the goal of the safety program - to have fewer injuries and illnesses than similar operations? to reduce by 10%?
- When confronted with conflicting priorities or allocation of limited resources, does safety get more importance? Equal importance? How is this decided?
- Is safety the responsibility of line management or staff management - who is accountable?
- What benefits does management expect to derive from an effective program?
- Who will be assigned responsibility for coordinating activities?



Who has responsibilities under the policy?

No matter how well written, a policy is no more than empty words if a plan does not exist to put the policy into effect throughout the organization. The policy can only be put into effect where:

- responsibilities are clearly defined and assigned,
- methods of accountability are established,
- proper procedures and program activities are implemented,
- adequate provision of financial and other resources are provided , and
- responsibilities for carrying out the policy objectives are clearly communicated and understood within the workplace.



Who has responsibilities under the policy?

Responsibility should be extended throughout the organizational structure to ensure policy objectives will become integrated into all activities. For example, a policy could specify:

- individual responsibilities ,
- legal responsibilities,
- accountability systems,
- promotion of health, safety and well-being awareness,
- education and training needs,
- reporting and correcting health and safety deficiencies, and
- injury and illness control information.



How can the policy be incorporated into regular workplace duties and actions?

Methods of establishing accountability should be designed to monitor the quality and adequacy of workplace procedures, including:

- inclusion of accountability in the statement of policy,
- inclusion of health and safety responsibilities and performance objectives in job descriptions,
- procedures for ensuring that health and health performance is considered as part of performance appraisals and salary reviews,
- regular health and safety program reviews, and
- regular reporting requirements built into program elements.



What are examples of how to communicate the policy to others?

An effective policy for health and safety management must be:

- clearly defined and communicated,
- backed up by sound arrangements and put into practice,
- reflected in day-to-day attitudes and actions of people, and
- monitored.



What are examples of how to communicate the policy to others?

Ways in which policy and responsibilities can be communicated include:

- orientation (induction) training,
- policy and procedure manuals,
- health and safety committees,
- job descriptions,
- website, notice board notices and reminders,
- safety talks, meetings, and refresher training,
- senior management attendance at safety meetings, and
- demonstration of senior management commitment through effective response and review to committee recommendation inspection reports, incident investigations, and health and safety program evaluations.



What are some suggestions for implementation of the policy?

- The policy should state that the workplace has clear rules for healthy and safe work behavior. It should clarify who is responsible for developing, observing, and enforcing the rules.
- There should be clear guidelines for maintaining and operating equipment and machinery. Again, individual responsibilities must be clarified.
- The policy should state what type of education or training program will be provided by the company to ensure that employees can meet their responsibilities. This learning could include first day orientation, on-the-job training, and refresher courses.
- The means for providing employees with information about basic or specific workplace hazards, and detailed written procedures for hazardous jobs should be outlined.
- Regular worksite health and safety meetings at all levels of the organization are an essential part of a good safety program. The policy could identify what issues will be discussed at these meetings, what can be communicated verbally, and what should be in writing.



What is an example of a policy checklist to review an existing or new policy?

Here is a sample of a series of questions that could be put in "Yes / No" checklist:

- Does the statement express a commitment to health, safety, and well-being? Are obligations towards employees made clear?
- Does it say which senior officer is responsible for seeing that it is implemented and for keeping it under review, and how this will be done?
- Is it signed by senior executive?
- Have the views of managers and supervisors, safety professionals, and health and safety committees or representatives been taken into account?
- Were the duties set out in the statement discussed with the people concerned? Do they understand how their performance is to be assessed and what resources they have to carry out their tasks safely?



What is an example of a policy checklist to review an existing or new policy?

- Does the statement make clear that cooperation on the part of all employees is vital to the success of the health and safety policy?
- Does it say how employees are to be involved in health and safety matters, for example, by being consulted, by taking part in inspections, or by participating on a health and safety committee?
- Does it show clearly how the duties for health and safety are allocated, and are the responsibilities at different levels described?
- Does it say who is responsible for the following matters?
 - Investigation reports and incident records.
 - Fire precautions and evacuation procedures.
 - First aid.
 - Safety inspections.
 - Education and training program.
 - Ensuring legal requirements are met.



Assignment

- Write a small policy document to your department laboratory.

